

Daily Bible Note

Date: May 26, 2026

I. Today's Reading

NKJV: 1 Corinthians 9:1–10

1 "Am I not an apostle? Am I not free? Have I not seen Jesus Christ our Lord? Are you not my work in the Lord?"

2 "If I am not an apostle to others, yet doubtless I am to you. For you are the seal of my apostleship in the Lord."

3 "My defense to those who examine me is this:"

4 "Do we have no right to eat and drink?"

5 "Do we have no right to take along a believing wife, as do also the other apostles, the brothers of the Lord, and Cephas?"

6 "Or is it only Barnabas and I who have no right to refrain from working?"

7 "Who ever goes to war at his own expense? Who plants a vineyard and does not eat of its fruit? Or who tends a flock and does not drink of the milk of the flock?"

8 "Do I say these things as a mere man? Or does not the law say the same also?"

9 "For it is written in the law of Moses, 'You shall not muzzle an ox while it treads out the grain.' Is it oxen God is concerned about?"

10 "Or does He say it altogether for our sakes? For our sakes, no doubt, this is written, that he who plows should plow in hope, and he who threshes in hope should be partaker of his hope."

II. Key Summary

- Paul defends his apostleship with three questions: he is free, he has seen the risen Christ, and the Corinthians' transformed lives are the living proof of his calling
- Using the examples of a soldier, a farmer, and a shepherd — backed by Old Testament law — Paul argues that those who serve the gospel have every right to be supported by it

- Even with a rock-solid case, Paul deliberately chooses not to claim this right, because getting the gospel out matters more to him than getting what he's owed
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III. Passage Analysis

Topic 1: Changed Lives Are the Strongest Evidence

"God would not give his sanction to an impostor, and a false pretender — their spiritual transformation under his ministry confirms his genuine apostolic calling." [1]

Paul's most convincing credential isn't a title or a résumé — it's the people standing right in front of him. When a work is real, the fruit speaks. The Corinthians' changed lives were Paul's seal, and no one could argue with that.

Topic 2: Having a Right — and Choosing Not to Use It

"Paid or not paid, it did not matter to him. What mattered was the work of the gospel. Was it more effective for the gospel if Paul should receive support? Then he would receive it. Was it more effective for the gospel if Paul should work to support himself? Then he would do that." [2]

Paul wasn't giving up his rights because he had no choice — he was making a trade on purpose: his own comfort and convenience, in exchange for a gospel that no one could accuse of being self-serving. That kind of voluntary sacrifice is rare, and it carries real weight.

IV. Reflection Question

Have you ever been in a situation where you were completely in the right — with every reason to stand your ground — but you let it go anyway, because something more important was at stake?

Paul made that trade because he had something he cared about more than being right. What's the thing you care about most — and does it ever shape the way you choose to give things up?

References

[1] BibleHub.com, Barnes' Notes on the Bible,

https://www.biblehub.com/commentaries/1_corinthians/9-1.htm

[2] Enduring Word, David Guzik Commentary, <https://enduringword.com/bible-commentary/1-corinthians-9/>